

BLACKOUTS & BITERS

A cooperative Pittsburgh zombie-response card game

QUICK RULES • SCENARIO BUILDER • d20 REQUIRED

Inspired by the open tabletop structure of *Backdoors & Breaches*
Adapted for emergency skills, credential tracks, and middle-school play.

Win before Pittsburgh goes dark

One person is the **Incident Guide**. Everyone else is a **Responder**. The Guide secretly selects one problem from each phase:

1. **Initial Aid Crisis** — the opening medical emergency
2. **Search & Drone Escalation** — where the incident spreads
3. **Signal & Coordination Failure** — why information breaks down
4. **Long-Haul Logistics** — what keeps the crisis alive

Responders win by revealing all four hidden problem cards within **10 turns**.

Setup

1. Sort and shuffle the four problem decks separately.
2. The Guide draws or chooses one from each and keeps them hidden.
3. Shuffle the Capability deck. Deal four face up as **Ready Skills**: these receive **+3**. Place every other capability face up with no bonus.
4. Shuffle Injects face down. Put a d20 and turn tracker nearby.
5. The Guide describes the opening scene mainly from the Initial Aid Crisis card, without naming it.

One turn: Talk • Choose • Roll • Learn

1. **Talk**: Responders ask questions and discuss which capability fits.
2. **Choose**: The group selects exactly one available Capability card. The track printed on that card leads the explanation.
3. **Roll**: Roll d20. Add +3 if it is a Ready Skill. **11+ succeeds; 10 or less fails**.
4. **Learn**: On success, if that capability's code appears on a hidden problem, the Guide reveals one matching card. If it matches none, the Guide gives a useful clue. On failure, the Guide explains what obstacle prevented useful information.
5. **Cooldown**: Turn the used capability sideways. It cannot be used for the next two turns.

Draw an Inject after a natural 1, natural 20, or three failed rolls in a row. Read it aloud and follow it.

Important: Cards describe exercise capabilities, not real permission to self-deploy. Students never enter a hot zone, diagnose patients, transmit outside license privileges, or fly without the adult PIC.

Incident Guide: build the story in 60 seconds

- 1. **Who needs help?** Start with the Initial Aid Crisis.
- 2. **Where does it lead?** Add the Search & Drone card.
- 3. **Why can't people coordinate?** Add Signal & Coordination.
- 4. **Why won't the problem simply end?** Add Long-Haul Logistics.
- 5. **Make it Pittsburgh:** choose a river, bridge, tunnel, neighborhood, hill, hospital district, stadium area, or warehouse corridor.

Example: “During a blackout, a bleeding stranger collapses outside a shelter in the Hill District. Their last words mention six people above floodwater on the South Side. The radio repeater fails, and the generator powering food refrigeration sits in rising water.”

Guide rules

- Answer reasonable questions without a roll when students would normally know the answer.
- Do not make students guess your exact words; reward a defensible use of a capability.
- If a roll fails, create a realistic reason: bad weather, exhausted staff, missing equipment, poor documentation, blocked route, rumor, or unsafe conditions.
- Reveal only one hidden card per successful turn.
- Keep horror fun and fictional. No physical attacks, surprise contact, or real emergency communications.

Turn tracker

Turn	Capability used	Roll + modifier	Result / clue	Cooldown / notes
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				
8				
9				
10				

Design note: This independent educational adaptation uses the cooperative hidden-card, capability-selection, d20, modifier, ten-turn, and inject structure described in the Backdoors & Breaches visual guide. It does not reproduce the original cards or cybersecurity text.